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Meetings All Over the World:

Structural and Psychological Characteristics of Meetings in Different Countries

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Abstract

Previous research on work meetings has mainly been conducted in the Anglo-Saxon context. In this chapter, we aim to contribute by adding an international perspective. Does the national context of the meeting influence how it is structured and perceived? We provide a descriptive-comparative empirical analysis of differences and commonalities in structural (i.e., size, length, frequency, lateness, the use of agenda, and action points) as well as psychological (i.e., participation, satisfaction, and mood) meeting characteristics. Our analysis is based on a survey study with 710 participants from 45 different countries. We first provide a comparison using a framework that classifies cultures according to the dimensions of space, time, and context, and next using seven country clusters identified in the context of the GLOBE study, namely Anglo (n = 91), Confucian Asia (n = 94), Eastern Europe (n = 242), Germanic Europe (n = 136), Latin Europe (n = 37), Middle East (n = 33), and Northern Europe (n = 70). We found important similarities, but also noteworthy differences in work meetings between locations. We discuss the emerging profile of cross-cultural meeting similarities and differences in light of its theoretical and managerial implications, and provide ideas for future research on meetings across cultures.

Keywords: work meeting; meeting characteristics; meeting perception; meeting structure; international; cross-cultural; globe country clusters

Introduction

A business meeting is typically defined as a type of communication in which purposeful work-related interactions occur between individuals that have more structure than a simple chat but less than a lecture (e.g., Rogelberg, 2007). Meetings can serve one or several functions in organizations, such as information sharing, decision-making, problem-solving, negotiation, morale building, exploration, and brainstorming (Cook, Ellis, Graf, Rein, & Smith, 1987). Although it is difficult to imagine any organization that does not have meetings, and the prevalence of meetings in day-to-day business is high, the research attention devoted to this topic has been relatively scarce (Rogelberg, Allen, Shanock, Scott, & Shuffler, 2010). Whereas there has been a pronounced research interest in other, related aspects of business life in organizations, such as team work (Kozlowski & Bell, 2003), considerably less attention has been devoted to the science of meetings although meetings were identified as a relevant topic of its own to study some time ago (Schwartzman, 1986).

This book, however, is one of the signs of growing interest in the topic, just as a recent special issue devoted solely to meetings at work (Scott, Shanock, & Rogelberg, 2012). These systematic approaches to studying the phenomenon of work meetings revealed important linkages of meeting characteristics and organizationally valued outcomes. For instance, research has shown that the time demands of meetings may affect employees' wellbeing (Rogelberg, Leach, Warr, & Burnfield, 2006); the satisfaction with meetings is important to job satisfaction (Rogelberg et al., 2010); and the behaviors in meetings are indicative of organizational success (Kauffeld & Lehmann-Willenbrock, 2012).

So far, most of the research on meetings has been conducted in the United States, or more broadly speaking, in Anglo-Saxon countries. There are a few exceptions, such as for example meeting studies conducted in the Caribbean, the Gulf Arab States, and Germany (Elsayed-Elkhouly, Lazarus, & Forsythe, 1997; Kemp & Williams, 2013; Köhler, Cramton,

& Hinds, 2012; Lehmann-Willenbrock, Allen, & Meinecke, 2013). However, overall, we know little about how meetings are designed and perceived in non-Anglo-Saxon settings. Yet, this knowledge is important given that research on cross-cultural organizational behavior has provided abundant evidence that organizational phenomena and their perceptions can vary across cultures (Gelfand, Erez, & Aycan, 2007). For instance, culture has shown to critically affect perceptions of behaviors such as negotiation and disputing; job-related attitudes; and teamwork (Gelfand et al., 2007). These are all relevant to meetings, an aspect of organizational life that is arguably shaped by the norms, the nature of roles, attitudes and beliefs, perceptions, and behaviors of organizational members and thus influenced by culture (Gelfand et al., 2007; Hofstede, 1980). But little is known about this phenomenon in the emerging field of science of meetings at work. To date we therefore still lack understanding of how culture may affect meetings. Different meeting habits or norms across cultures may have developed historically. For example, Van Vree (1999; 2002) demonstrated that the historical-political roots of meetings in the Netherlands still resonate in how the Dutch conduct meetings today. In sum, culture may be an important determinant of how meetings are conducted and, as a consequence, of how they are perceived, and what their outcomes are.

Considering a country as a cultural setting, we therefore set out to study whether similarities or differences regarding structural and psychological characteristics of work meetings across these settings prevail. In order to explore this issue, we draw on an international survey, and examine differences and similarities of how meetings are held and perceived in 45 countries. In so doing, this study aims to contribute to the literature on work meetings by presenting research findings on meetings characteristics obtained in a wider range of countries than previously examined. As a managerial implication, the present research provides input for meeting management in shaping the structural and psychological aspects of work meetings, and what this could mean in different cultural settings.

Culture and the Characteristics of Work Meetings

The way work meetings are held and perceived (i.e., the characteristics of work meetings) has an important impact on organizationally relevant outcomes (Rogelberg et al., 2006; Rogelberg et al., 2010). Whereas structural or design-related meeting characteristics reflect how meetings are conducted, psychological characteristics provide insights into how participants perceive and experience meetings. To investigate whether the country context, and by implication its cultural setting, influences meetings, we base our descriptive-comparative analysis on both structural and psychological characteristics of meetings in the present study. Figure 1 shows how we examined the nature of work meetings, as evident in both structural and psychological meetings characteristics, within two frameworks to qualify cultural differences. In the following, we will describe the characteristics investigated in the present study in more detail.

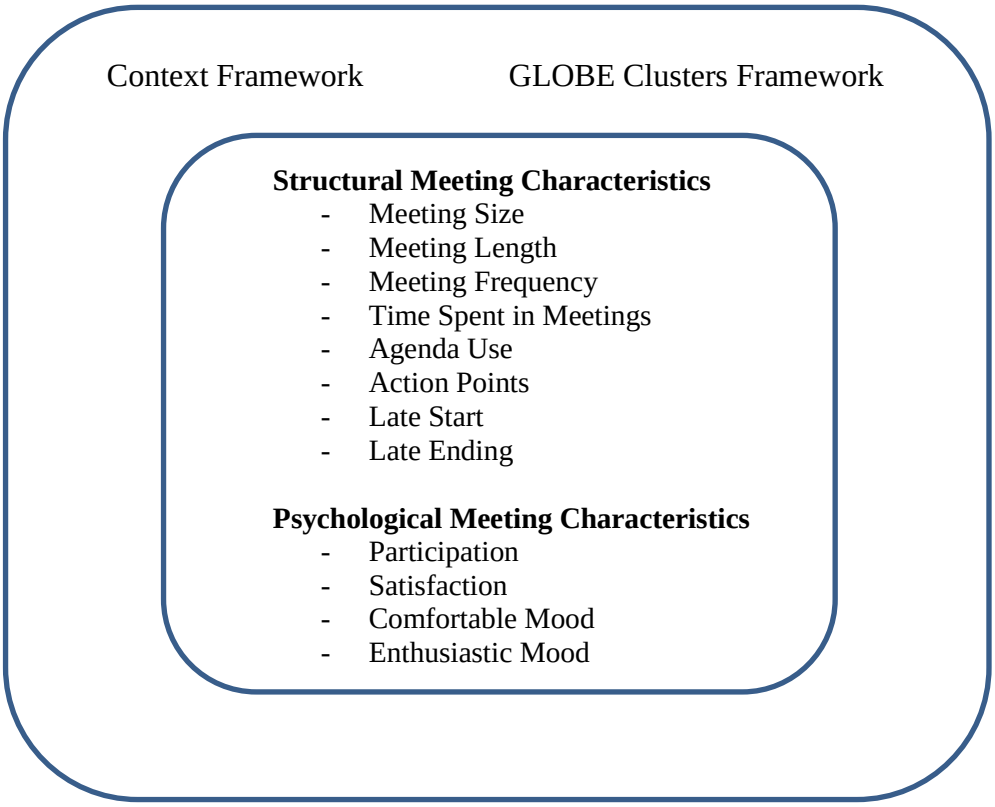


Figure 1. Overview of study variables.

Structural Meeting Characteristics

By structural meeting characteristics, we mean characteristics of the meeting that have to do with the design in terms of temporal, procedural, and attendee characteristics that are important for the perception of the quality of the meeting (Cohen, Rogelberg, Allen, & Luong, 2011). In the current study, we focus on the number of attendees (i.e., meeting size); meeting length and time spent in meetings as part of a workweek; the use of an agenda; the use of action points; and meeting punctuality (starting and ending promptness).

Meetings serve as communication tools that groups of people utilize to attain work-related goals (Cohen et al., 2011). Meeting size may affect how successfully this tool can be employed. The number of participants in a meeting (i.e., meeting size) influences collaboration and communication in meetings. Group research has revealed that larger group sizes can lower group functioning and performance. The increased demands of coordination, the lowered ability to seek and use every group member's unique input, the lowered participation of individual group members, the lowered ability for joint decision-making, group-think phenomena, and the reduced involvement of some group members all play a role (e.g., LePine, Piccolo, Jackson, Mathieu, & Saul, 2008). This is likely to also occur in work meetings. Cohen et al. (2011) showed that the number of attendees was negatively related to perceived meeting quality.

Meeting length refers to how meeting time is used, and time management of meetings is important to their outcomes (Allen & Rogelberg, 2013). We included meeting length given prior research's focus on this variable and the time demands it places on participants, with possible negative repercussions for their wellbeing (Luong & Rogelberg, 2005; Rogelberg et al., 2006). However, Leach, Rogelberg, Warr, and Burnfield (2009) found that the duration of a meeting was positively related to the involvement of participants in the meeting. Thus, it may be favorably linked to relevant meeting outcomes.

Meeting punctuality refers to two aspects, namely the starting and ending promptness, and reflects the degree to which temporal courtesy is upheld (Cohen et al., 2011). Late starts can be perceived as disruptive (Luong & Rogelberg, 2005), and inhibit the coordination and scheduling of work (Cohen et al., 2011). Consistent with this reasoning, empirical research reveals that meeting punctuality, both in terms of starting and ending promptness, is related to higher meeting success (i.e., perceived quality and effectiveness; Cohen et al., 2011; Leach et al., 2009).

Another structural characteristic of work meetings studied here is the use of an agenda. As Cohen et al. (2011) suggest, this procedural characteristic of work meetings increases the participants' task focus, helps them work toward the meeting goals, and facilitates important follow-up activities with respect to the meeting. Consistent with this, prior research has revealed that agenda use in a meeting is linked to perceived meeting effectiveness (Leach et al., 2009).

Relatedly, action points may contribute to effective meeting procedures. Action points are points of attention that result from agenda points. They are marked as important for follow-up, and their fulfillment is then recaptured in the following meeting. According to Cohen et al. (2011), procedural characteristics of work meetings are essential for perceptions of meeting quality because they target the fulfillment of expectations of the participants by increasing the commitment to and agreement with the outcomes of meetings. We propose that action points contribute to these perceptions of expectation fulfillment, and therefore include them in the present study.

To increase understanding of meetings in different countries, we focus on the above outlined variables as structural determinants of meetings. These structural characteristics may inform us about the habits formed in holding meetings. For example, long meetings with

many participants may indicate that extensive information sharing among meeting participants is valued, which may vary across countries or larger geographical regions.

Psychological Meeting Characteristics

Besides this more factual information on meetings, perceptions and experiences of individuals (i.e., psychological characteristics of work meetings) are also important. We focus on participation in, satisfaction with, and mood in the meeting.

Participation in meetings refers to the degree to which meeting participants make active contributions to the meeting, such as expressing ideas and unique viewpoints, sharing knowledge, and expressing consent or disagreement. Given that participation is at the core of the functions of meetings, i.e., information sharing, decision-making, problem-solving, negotiation, morale building, exploration, and brainstorming (Cook et al., 1987), the degree of participation is considered to be an important characteristic of meetings. In fact, Rogelberg et al. (2006) suggest that participation in meetings is positively linked to the quality and effectiveness of meetings. Culture may profoundly influence participation (Sagie & Aycan, 2003). As Hofstede (2001) noted, “(o)ne cannot write meaningfully about organizational participation without embedding it within a national cultural context” (p. 109). For instance, countries differ on the cultural value of power distance, i.e., the acceptance of power hierarchies and inequality, which influences the degree of participation (Sagie & Aycan, 2003).

Another psychological characteristic of meetings is satisfaction with the meeting. Satisfaction with meetings, defined as the “overall affective reactions to meetings” (Rogelberg et al., 2010, p. 164), is assumed to be an important meeting-related attitude resulting from meetings and the cumulated affects created by them. Satisfaction with meetings is a (distinct) facet of job satisfaction that determines overall job satisfaction (Rogelberg et al., 2010). Importantly, satisfaction with various job-related aspects has been

found to vary as a function of national culture and country (Gelfand et al., 2007). For instance, Spector and colleagues (2007) found cross-national differences in job satisfaction (e.g., between Anglo and Asian countries). Given these linkages among country clusters and satisfaction, we focus on satisfaction with meetings as a psychological meeting characteristic that may reveal possible distinctions between countries.

A third psychological characteristic of meetings studied in the present research is mood. Affective events theory (Weiss & Cropanzano, 1996) suggests that work events, such as those related to the job work activities, or the workplace, engender momentary affective experiences in employees. Meetings may be such events in which failures and successes become apparent. Meetings are therefore argued to generate affect (Rogelberg et al., 2010). Mood captures these momentary affective experiences in employees, and is linked to a number of organizationally relevant outcomes in work settings. Affective responses of individuals appear to be influenced by culture (e.g., happiness, Diener, 2000). Following Rogelberg et al. (2006), we focus on two forms of mood that are assumed to be of specific relevance in the context of meetings: 1) comfortable and 2) enthusiastic mood. With respect to the first dimension, anxiety – comfort, an anxious mood would create an avoidance perspective where people focus on limiting risks and are vigilant, whereas comfort indicates an approach perspective, associated with openness, creativity, and achievement. Anxiety versus comfort may thus affect the outcomes of the meeting. It is also important to realize that there may be cultural differences in information processing. For example, in the Japanese culture, an avoidance approach is preferred whereas the US-American culture is characterized by an approach orientation (Hamamura, Meijer, Heine, Kamaya, & Hori, 2009). With respect to the second dimension, depression – enthusiasm, it may be reasoned if it is high, that the team spirit, energy, and the focus on action is high, with important implications for the outcomes of meetings.

Cultural Frameworks Employed in This Study

We used two frameworks to assess possible differences and similarities between the countries with regard to the structural and psychological characteristics of meetings. First, we employed a classification of countries proposed by Holtbrügge, Weldon, and Rogers (2013, see p. 100 for the research base to distinguish these countries) that is based upon Hall's (1983) taxonomy and related to the GLOBE clusters. Second, we used the GLOBE country cluster framework (Gupta, Hanges, & Dorfman, 2002).

The first framework employed in this study is a general framework of cultures, namely Hall's (1983) classification that highlights distinctions in how people interact in terms of (a) space (low-high); (b) time (monochronic-polychronic); and (c) style of communication (high-low context). First, space refers to an individual's personal space. It can mean physical distance that is perceived as appropriate, but also the extent to which space is considered private. Second, with regard to time, it is important whether time is tangible, seen as a resource that can be used in a linear fashion, where activities are performed in a sequential manner (monochronic), versus a view of time as part of an event, where activities are not clearly separated and attention to activities switches frequently (polychronic). Third, context describes the extent to which a message is specifically contained in a verbal direct communication (low context), or where words are embroidered by the context of a message by such factors as the event where the communication takes place, and nonverbal or paralingual signs. In the latter case, communication is indirect (high context). Holtbrügge, Weldon, and Rogers (2013) used a classification of countries based upon Hall's concepts that we follow here. It is a general classification into two categories, and partly overlapping with the GLOBE clusters as we will explain below. The first category contains high space / monochronic / low context countries. These are countries with a Germanic, Anglo-Saxon, and Nordic background, with the exception of the Nordic countries that were formerly part of

the Soviet Union (see Appendix). The second category contains all other countries, and is characterized as low space / polychronic / high context. Holtbrügge et al. (2013) found that this classification was relevant to preferences regarding email use. They concluded that cultural background had a significant impact on the preference for formalness, promptness, preciseness, task-relatedness, and relationship-relatedness in email communication. In this study we examine whether the cultural differences also apply to another communication tool in organizations, namely face-to-face communication in meetings. We will refer to this two-group classification as “context classification”.

The second framework we use to compare the countries is the GLOBE country cluster framework (Gupta, Hanges, & Dorfman, 2002). The GLOBE (Global Leadership and Organizational Behavior Effectiveness Research) study is based on Hofstede’s (1980) work that revealed systematic differences between countries in their cultural values, namely power distance, masculinity versus femininity, individualism versus collectivism, and uncertainty avoidance. More specifically, the GLOBE study represents a large-scale research project across 62 nations to examine the relationships between culture, organizational processes, and leadership in organizations (Hanges, Javidan, Dorfman, & Gupta, 2004).

This research resulted in ten country clusters: Anglo (e.g., Great Britain, United States); Middle East (e.g., Egypt); Confucian Asia (e.g., China); Eastern Europe (e.g., Romania); Germanic Europe (e.g., Germany, The Netherlands); Latin America (e.g., Argentina); Latin Europe (e.g., Spain); Northern Europe (e.g., Finland); Southern Asia (e.g., Singapore); and Sub-Sahara Africa (e.g., Namibia). These clusters constitute an empirically established basis for assembling countries into larger conjunctions based upon their similarities.

More specifically, countries are clustered according to systematic within-cluster similarities and between-cluster differences in culture on the basis of regional and climatic

criteria. Hence, these clusters may also allow us to capture similarities and differences in the way meetings are conducted, perceived, and experienced as a function of culture.

Method

Sample

The study was conducted using internal meetings at different companies in different sectors. Participants were chosen based on their recent involvement in an internal face-to-face business meeting. The participant served as a single informant of the most recent meeting. The meeting had to meet several criteria: it had to be held in a professional organizational work setting, it had to be conducted internally in an organization, there had to be three or more persons but less than 23 persons as a cutoff of the group size, there had to be a chairperson facilitating the meeting, and it had to be scheduled in advance. Participants were contacted by students in a research class. Questionnaires were sent by e-mail and received on paper or digitally.

The sample consisted of respondents from meetings held in 45 countries (see Appendix). Respondents were in the age range of 21 to 65, with a mean age of 32.7 (*SD* = 9.2). 47% of the respondents were female. Asked about the meeting type, respondents indicated that 34.7% of the meetings were about information-sharing, 35.8% about routine issues, 22.7% about special problems, and 6.8% about another type of meeting. Mostly, participants worked in a private company (72.2 %, versus private non-profit 9.5% and public 18.2%). The industries in which the meetings took place were: service (27.3%); other (27.3%); industry (20.6%); banking (15.2%); and education (9.5%). 18.3% of the respondents indicated they were the person who had chaired the meeting.

Measures

The survey was conducted in English.

Structural characteristics. The average group size in the meeting was 8.8 (*SD* = 4.3). The average duration of the meeting was 80.6 minutes (*SD* = 76.9). The average number of meetings attended during a week was 3.7 (*SD* = 3.6). Time spent in meetings was estimated by the respondents as 16.7% (*SD* = 14.6). To capture starting late and ending late, we asked respondents to indicate whether the meeting started and/or ended late, and if so, how many minutes. Meetings started on average 51 minutes late (*SD* = 14.3), and ended on average 8.3 minutes late (*SD* = 16.0). Being asked regarding the use of an agenda, respondents indicated that an agenda had been used in on average 59% of the meetings (*SD* = 49.3). In on average 64% of the meetings, action points had been used (*SD* = 47.9)

Psychological characteristics. For measuring *participation in the meeting*, respondents answered the following items: "Participation was widespread among meeting attendees"; "Participants worked hard"; "A variety of options was explored before making decisions"; and "Consequences of decisions were explored before final decisions were made" (α = .69).

The four items used to measure *satisfaction with the meeting* were "I am satisfied with the meeting"; "I am satisfied with how the meeting went"; "I am satisfied with the results achieved"; and "I am satisfied with how the relationship of the members developed" (α = .81).

Mood in the meeting was measured using a well-being scale developed by Warr (1990). For both the anxiety-comfort and depression-enthusiasm axis of this scale, we asked the respondents how they felt during the meeting. With respect to the anxiety-comfort axis of mood or well-being, respondents rated the following words: tense (reverse-coded), anxious (reverse-coded), calm, relaxed, worried (reverse-coded), and comfortable (α = .80).

The scale capturing the depression-enthusiasm axis of well-being included the following words: Optimistic, gloomy (reverse-coded), motivated, depressed (reverse-coded), miserable (reverse-coded), and enthusiastic." (α = .75).

All scales measuring the psychological characteristics had response options on a five-point Likert scale, ranging from 1 = *Disagree completely* to 5 = *Agree completely*.

Country Clustering

As explained above, we conducted our comparative analyses of countries according to the structural and psychological characteristics of meetings by means of two distinct taxonomies, a general and a more focused framework: context classification and GLOBE clusters.

Context classification. The context classification distinguishes two distinct categories (Holtbrügge et al., 2013). High space / monochronic / low context countries are countries with a Germanic, Anglo-Saxon, and Nordic background, with the exception of the Nordic countries that were formerly part of the Soviet Union. All other countries are resembled in the cluster of low space / polychronic / high context countries (see Appendix, last column).

GLOBE clusters classification. Respondents indicated in which country the meeting was held. We grouped these countries according to the clusters identified in the GLOBE study (Gupta et al., 2002; House, Javidan, Hanges, & Dorfman, 2002). From the proposed ten clusters, seven clusters were represented in our sample: Anglo (ANG); Confucian Asia (CONF); Eastern Europe (EAS); Germanic Europe (GER); Latin Europe (LAT); Middle East (ME); and Northern Europe (NOR). The countries and clusters are provided in the Appendix.

Data Analysis

For the comparison within both frameworks explained above, we conducted a multivariate analysis of variance, controlling for age of the participant, and whether the respondent fulfilled the role of the facilitator. Although we initially controlled for the gender

of the respondent, we noticed that there were no effects, and we removed it as a control variable. The age and facilitator role were significantly correlated ($r = .23$, $p < .01$). We analyzed the variance of the combined structural characteristics, and of the combined psychological characteristics separately in a multivariate analysis. Age and facilitator role both had a significant effect on the two types of characteristics. Additionally, for the GLOBE clusters, we carried out post-hoc analyses using a Bonferroni test to determine whether there were differences between pairs of GLOBE clusters if we found a multivariate effect for these characteristics.

Results

The correlations between the variables and the reliabilities of the scales are shown in Table 1. It can be seen that structural and psychological characteristics are related only slightly, indicating that the structure of a meeting has only minor influence on how a meeting is perceived and experienced. Within the significant relations, the size of the meeting is important: With larger meeting sizes, participation is seen as less, and people are less satisfied and enthusiastic. A late ending is unrelated to participation, but is negatively related to satisfaction and mood.

Structural Characteristics

The multivariate analysis of variance for the structural characteristics revealed a significant overall effect for the context classification, $F(8, 689) = 2.09$, $p < .05$. The multivariate analysis of variance for the structural characteristics revealed a significant overall effect for the GLOBE clusters, $F(48, 4134) = 3.06$, $p < .01$. Thus, we proceeded to interpret the univariate effects.

Table 1

Means, Standard Deviations, and Correlations

	M	*SD*	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13
1. Age	32.68	9.28													
2. Facilitator role	.19	.39	.23												
3. Size	8.19	4.31	-.05	-.04											
4. Length	80.68	77.19	.09	.13	.15										
5. Frequency	3.68	3.55	.17	.27	-.04	.12									
6. Time spent	16.73	14.67	.18	.30	-.06	.14	.68								
7. Agenda	.58	.49	.06	.00	.12	.17	-.01	.02							
8. Action points	.65	.48	.02	.05	-.06	.13	.07	.08	.19						
9. Late start	5.07	14.38	-.08	-.09	-.09	.01	.00	-.04	.00	.03					
10. Late ending	8.03	15.55	-.08	-.01	.00	.14	-.04	.01	.03	.00	.21				
11. Participation	3.62	.72	.09	.08	-.19	.10	.07	.12	-.01	.13	-.09	.02			
12. Satisfaction	3.58	.70	.03	.14	-.10	.04	.08	.05	.00	.05	-.10	-.16	.43		
13. Comfortable Mood	3.63	.72	.13	.02	.02	.00	.03	.02	.01	-.01	-.06	-.18	.17	.38	
14. Enthusiastic Mood	3.83	.67	.06	.17	-.09	.03	.11	.10	.03	.02	-.04	-.12	.34	.52	.46

Note. N = 710. $r > .07$ is significant at the .05 level, and $r > .10$ at the .01 level.

Meeting size. The analysis of variance showed that meeting size did not differ for the context classification, $F(1,696) = .80$, $p = .371$. However, it differed significantly between the GLOBE clusters, $F(6,691) = 7.21$, $p < .001$. The post-hoc analysis showed that the Confucian Asian cluster has on average two to three more persons in their meetings than all other clusters (10 vs. 7 or 8). Figure 2 shows all observed averages per cluster.

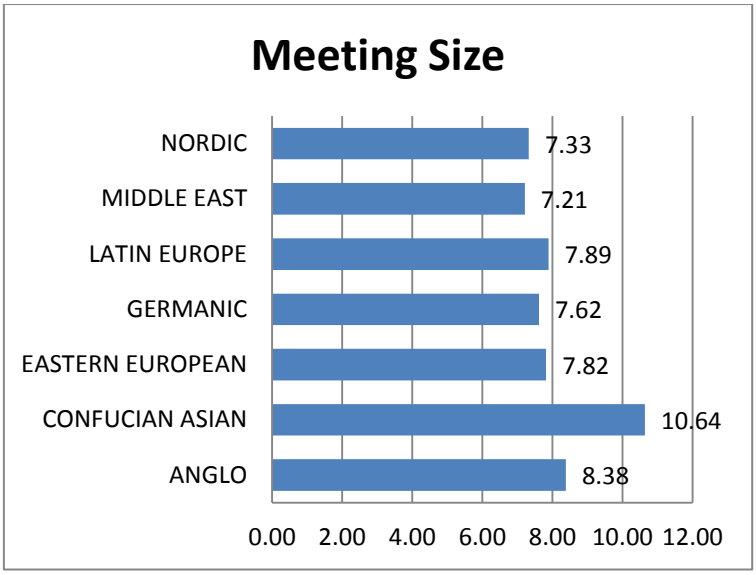


Figure 2. Average meeting size in the GLOBE clusters.

Meeting length. The duration of the meeting differed significantly between the groups within the context classification, $F(1,696) = 6.90$, $p < .01$, with the low context countries having longer meetings (M = 1 hour 32 minutes) compared to the high context countries (M = 1 hour 14 minutes).

In Figure 3 the average meeting duration is displayed for the clusters. Overall, the variation was significantly different between the GLOBE clusters, $F(6,691) = 2.75$, $p < .05$. The post-hoc comparisons revealed that the Anglo[1] cluster had significantly longer meeting times (M = 1 hour 48 minutes) than the Eastern European cluster (M = 1 hour 12 minutes).

[1] Focusing on the results within the cluster, we found that there were some extreme values in Great Britain that can explain the results – the US values were not extreme. This leads to different averages: 158 minutes (SD = 238) in the UK and 69 minutes (SD = 33) in the US.

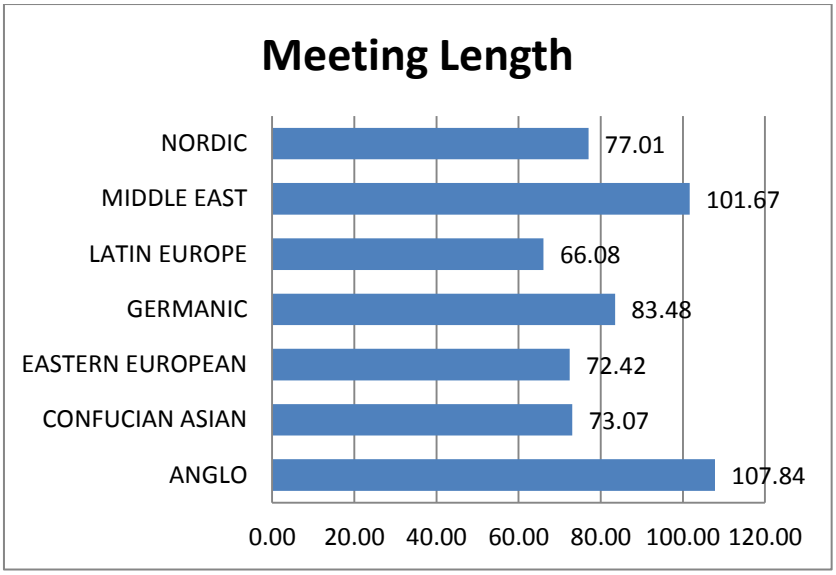


Figure 3. Meeting length in the GLOBE clusters.

Meeting frequency per week. Respondents provided the average number of times they were in meetings during a week. The analysis of variance showed that the number of meetings per week did not differ for the context classification, $F(1,696) = .69$, $p = .408$. Figure 4 provides the numbers of each of the clusters, ranging from an average of 2.83 (SD = 2.15) in the Latin European cluster to an average of 4.70 (SD = 3.86) in the Anglo cluster. The overall analysis of variance, however, was not significant, $F(6,697) = 1.45$, $p = .192$.

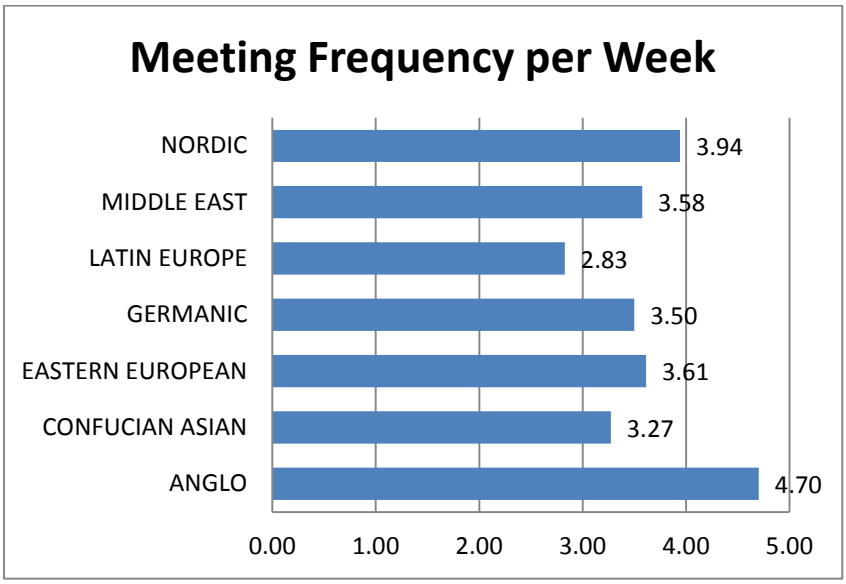


Figure 4. Number of meetings per week in the GLOBE clusters.

Time spent in meetings. On average, the participants responded that they spend 17% of their time in meetings. The analysis of variance showed that time spent in meetings did not differ for the context classification, but there was a significant difference between the GLOBE clusters, $F(6,691) = 2.44$, $p < .05$. The post-hoc comparisons revealed that the Anglo cluster spent considerably more time in meetings (22%) than the Germanic cluster (15%). Comparisons between the country clusters are displayed in Figure 5.

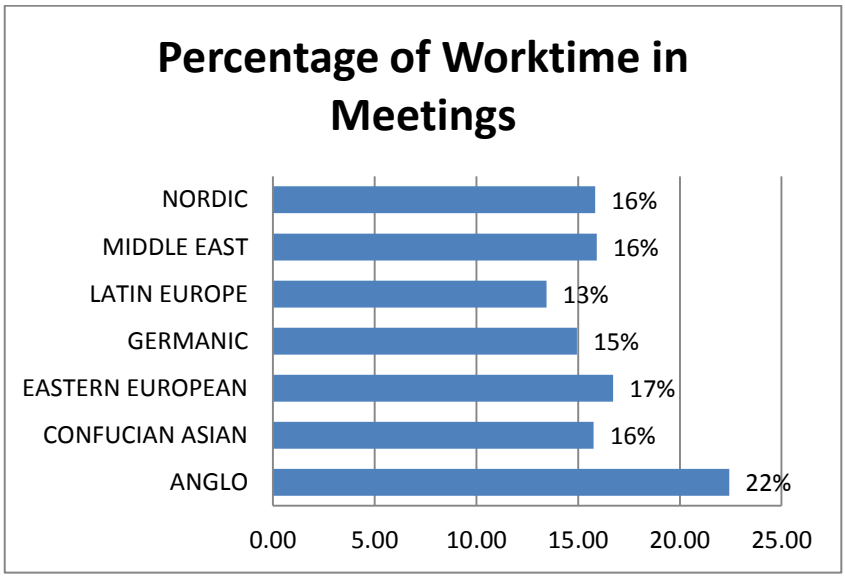
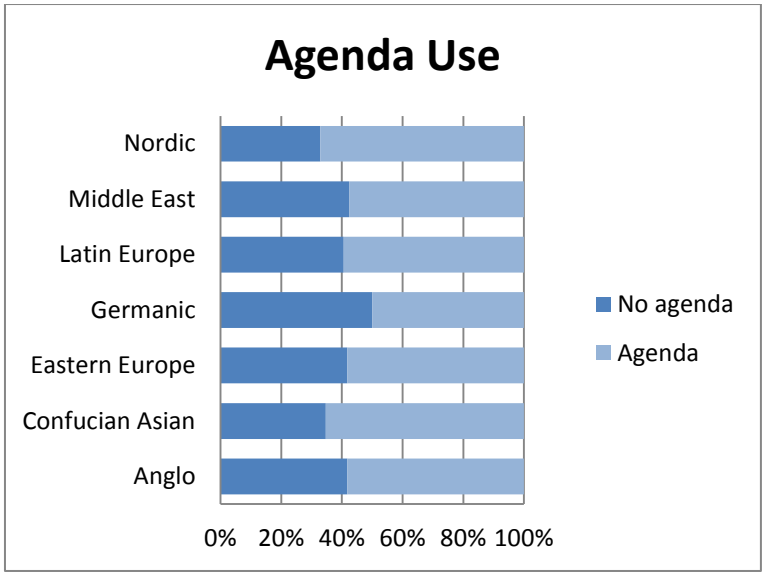


Figure 5. Percentage of time spent in meetings in the GLOBE clusters.

Agenda use. The analysis of variance showed that agenda use did not differ for the context classification, $F(6,691) = 1.82$, $p = .178$. Figure 6 displays the values for the clusters that indicate whether an agenda was used in the meeting. Although there appear to be some differences, the results were not significantly different, $F(6,691) = 1.39$, $p = 216$.



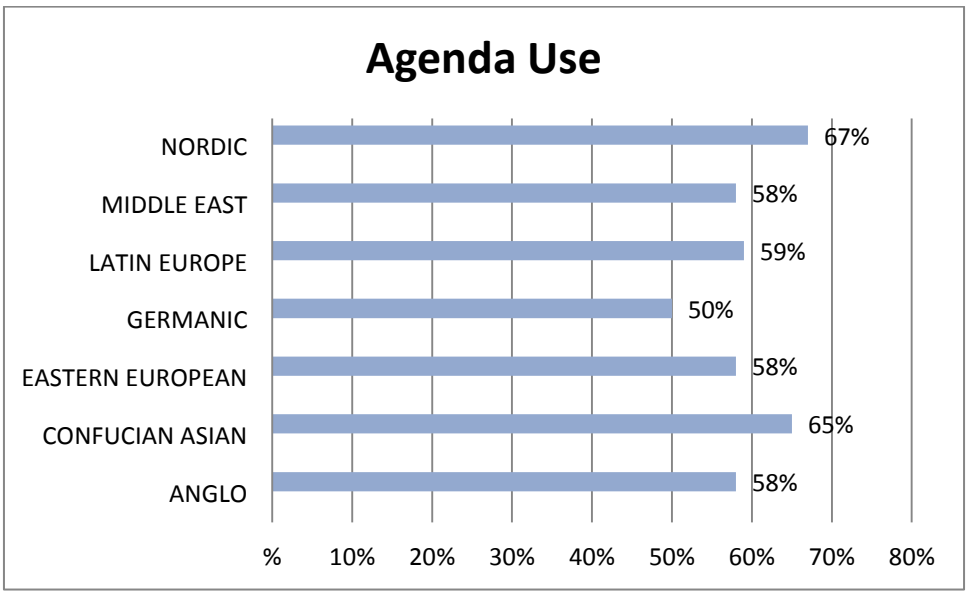


Figure 6. Agenda use in the GLOBE clusters.

Action points. With regard to the context classification, the analysis of variance revealed a difference regarding the use of action points. Low context countries used action points more (M = 70%, SD = .49) than high context countries (M = 62%, SD = .46). Figure 7 displays the values for the clusters that indicate whether action points were used in the meeting. The results are significantly different, $F(6,691) = 2.81$, $p < .01$. The pairwise comparison revealed that in the Anglo cluster action points were used significantly more often than in the Confucian Asian cluster.

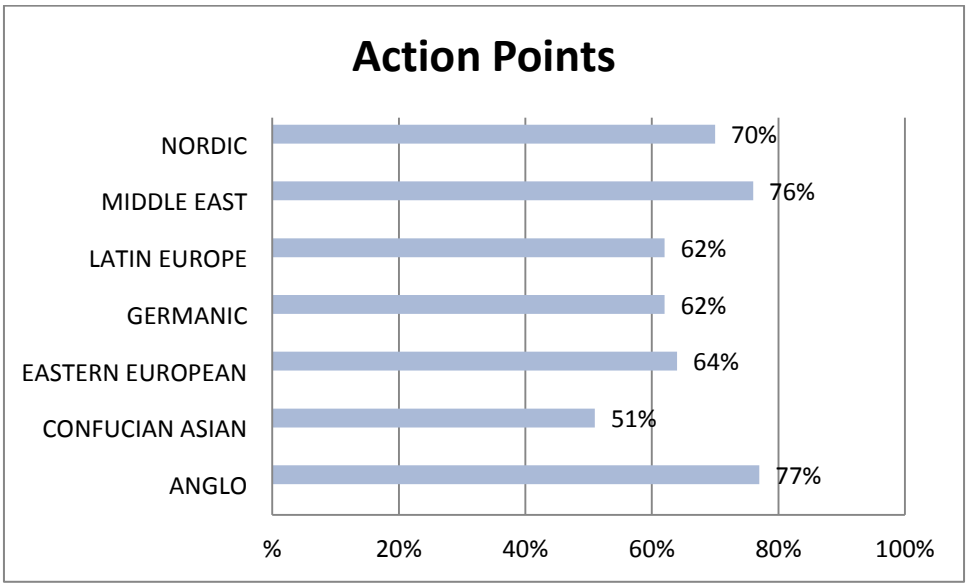


Figure 7. Use of action points in the GLOBE clusters.

Starting late. Figure 8 shows that most meetings do not start late, on average only five minutes. The analysis of variance showed that starting late did not differ for the context classification. However, the analysis of variance shows considerable and significant variation between the clusters, $F(6,691) = 7.51$, $p < .001$. Post hoc analysis showed that in the Middle Eastern cluster, meetings started significantly later than planned, about 20 minutes late.

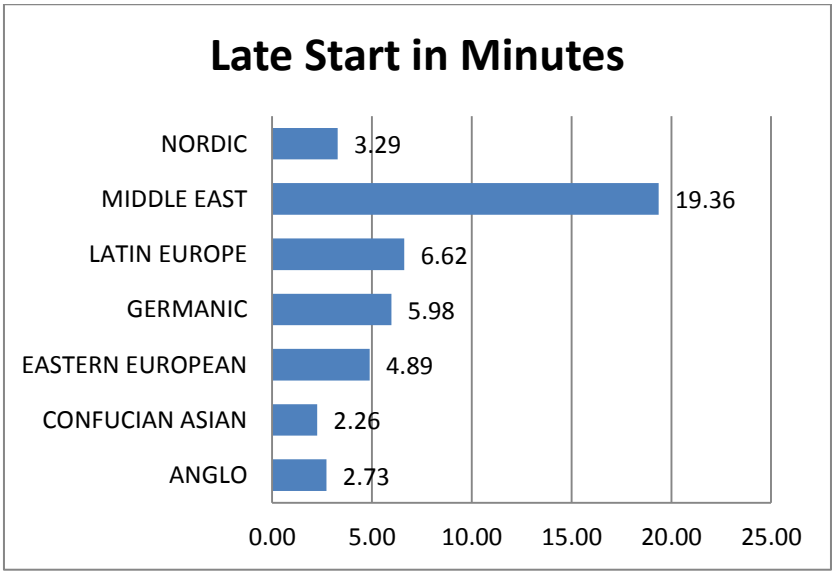


Figure 8. Late start in the GLOBE clusters.

Ending late. Figure 9 shows that most meetings do not end late, on average about eight minutes (*SD* = 4.28). The analysis of variance showed that ending late did not differ for the context classification. With regard to the clusters, ending late ranged between 4.90 minutes (Anglo cluster) and 9.85 minutes (Middle Eastern cluster). The analysis of variance shows no significant variation between the clusters, $F(6,703) = 1.390$, $p = .261$.

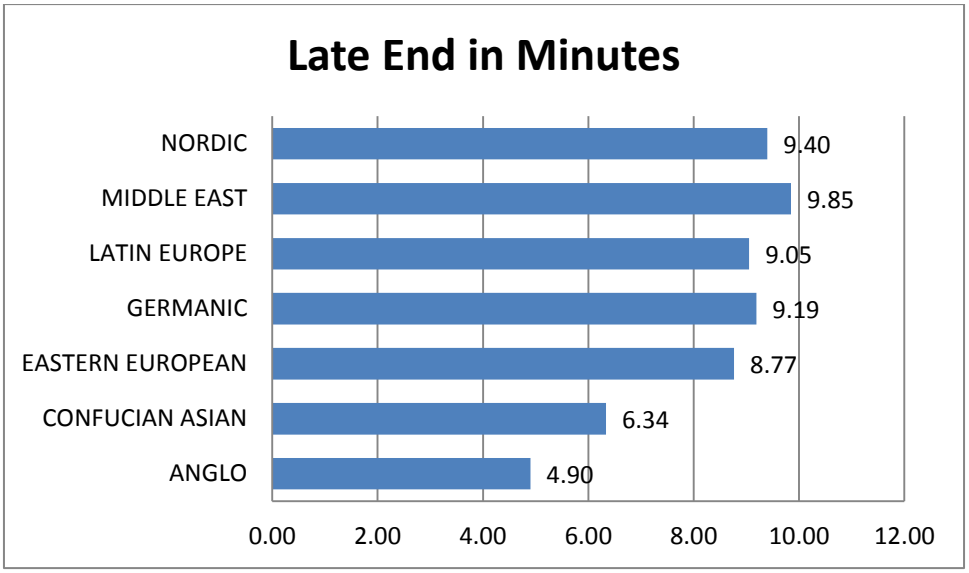


Figure 9. Late end in the GLOBE clusters.

Psychological Characteristics

The overall analysis of variance for the psychological characteristics was significant, both for the context classification, $F(4, 700) = 3.89$, $p = < .01$, and the GLOBE clusters, $F(24, 2792) = 2.00$, $p < .01$. Thus, we proceeded to analyze the univariate effects.

Participation. Overall, respondents indicated that participation was high (*M* = 3.62, *SD* = .71). There was a significant difference between the countries according to the context classification, $F(1,703) = .88$, $p = .348$, and no differences were detected for the perceptions of participation in the meetings between the clusters, $F(6,698) = .93$, $p = .476$.

Satisfaction. Overall, respondents were satisfied with the meetings (*M* = 3.58, *SD* = .71). There was no significant difference between the countries according to the context

classification, $F(1,703) = .11$, $p = .739$. No differences were detected between the GLOBE clusters, $F(6,698) = .43$, $p = .853$.

Anxiety - comfort. Overall, respondents indicated that they were more comfortable than anxious ($M = 3.63$, $SD = .72$). There was a significant difference between the countries according to the context classification, $F(1,703) = 13.24$, $p < .001$, with the low context countries feeling more comfortable. There was also a significant difference in comfort between the clusters, $F(6,698) = 4.18$, $p < .001$. The pairwise comparison showed that the Anglo and Germanic clusters reported significantly higher comfort than the Latin European and Middle Eastern clusters.

Depression – enthusiasm. Overall, respondents indicated that they felt quite enthusiastic in the meeting ($M = 3.82$, $SD = .67$). There was no significant difference between the countries according to the context classification, $F(1,703) = 1.07$, $p = .300$. In contrast, there was a significant difference in enthusiasm between the clusters, $F(6,698) = 2.99$, $p < .01$. However, the pairwise comparisons were non-significant. Table 2 provides an overview of the comparisons.

Table 2

Overview of research results

	Context Classification Different?	Clusters Different?	Pairwise Difference
Size	No	Yes	Confucian Asian > all other clusters
Length	Yes	Yes	Anglo > Eastern European
Number meetings per week	No	No	-
Time in meetings	No	Yes	Anglo > Germanic
Agenda	No	No	-
Action points	Yes	Yes	Anglo > Confucian Asian
Late start	No	Yes	Middle Eastern > all other clusters
Late end	No	No	-

Participation	No	No	-
Satisfaction	No	No	-
Comfort	Yes	Yes	Anglo, Germanic > Latin European, Middle Eastern
Enthusiasm	No	Yes	-

Discussion

In this study, we compared structural and psychological characteristics of work meetings in 45 different nations. First, we compared meetings in high and low context countries in the framework of the context classification. Then, following the categorization of countries according to the GLOBE country clusters, we compared meetings in the seven country clusters represented in our sample. We found that there were overall differences in meeting characteristics between the clusters (controlling for age and the role of facilitator of the respondents).

Focusing on each of the structural characteristics, we did not find differences using the context framework, except for the length of the meeting (longer in low context countries) and the use of action points (higher in low context countries). Using the GLOBE framework for comparison, we did not find differences with respect to the average number of meetings held per week, agenda use, and ending late between the various country clusters. However, there were notable differences regarding the other structural aspects. Specifically, we found that Confucian Asian countries had more participants in a meeting than all other clusters. Also, we found that meetings lasted significantly longer in the Anglo cluster than in the Eastern European cluster. Furthermore, action points were used more often in meetings held in the Anglo cluster than in the Confucian Asian cluster. Another significant difference we observed was the later start of meetings in the Middle Eastern cluster in comparison to all other clusters.

The results on the structural characteristics can be compared to Cohen et al.'s (2011) study using an American sample. They also found that about 10 to 11 persons took part in meetings, a size comparable to the Confucian Asian cluster, which was significantly larger than in the other clusters represented in our study. The duration and starting promptness they found were more or less equal to the current study. However, the use of an agenda was markedly less (34%) in their study – although their more detailed specification of what an agenda is (also available in advance) may have reduced this number. Comparing our results with those from another American sample (Leach et al., 2009), we could also find that longer meetings were related to more participation, or in their study, involvement.

The result of a later start in the Middle Eastern cluster confirms the findings of a study in the Gulf Arab states (Kemp & Williams, 2013). Based upon their findings, the authors conclude that meeting times were treated rather flexibly, as visible not only in a late start of meetings, but also in a general lack of time boundaries (e.g., occurrence and acceptance of interruptions). This would also be expected regarding the time dimension in Hall's (1983) framework. However, this study used a combination of space, time, and context rather than the time dimension alone, which did not allow for using time to distinguish between the countries. However, it sheds a different light on Rogelberg et al.'s (2014) study on lateness to meetings. The study was conducted in the Southeastern United States and as such may be culturally bound. Lateness in meetings, and the use of time in general, also regarding other time management issues (e.g., goals and deadlines), across various cultural settings would be important to address in future research. In fact, time management appears to be a major difficulty in international teams (Williams & van Eerde, 2014).

With regard to the difference between the Confucian Asian and Anglo clusters in the use of action points, we believe that this may indicate differences in the communication tools between high and low context countries: the more explicit, the more low context. Action

points are very explicit and they express the expectations regarding the roles of the participants. That is, they serve as reminders of actions and they often also ascribe which person is responsible for these actions. This personal responsibility may be typical for more individualistic cultures.

The country clusters were also characterized by overall differences when psychological characteristics of meetings were concerned. However, the perceptions of participation and satisfaction did not differ, only the mood perceptions. Here, we found that people in high context cultures felt more anxious. More specifically, respondents in meetings in the Latin European and Middle Eastern clusters felt more anxious than in the Anglo and Germanic countries.

Comparing our results on mood with another American sample, we also found that those who spend more times in meetings (Luong & Rogelberg, 2005) and have more meetings per week were more enthusiastic. Although there was significant variation in enthusiasm between the clusters, it could not be ascribed to certain clusters.

Theoretical Implications

The present study contributes to the emerging field of meeting science by adding an international perspective on the input variables of meetings to the existent body of meeting knowledge. As in other areas of research, studies investigating meetings have predominantly focused on a Western setting, and left unconsidered potential cultural differences in how meetings are held and perceived. As far as we are aware, this is the first study that systematically compared phenomena within meetings using a large sample across many different countries. It thus extends prior research's predominant focus on Western cultural settings to also include non-Western countries. Particularly, Eastern European (n = 241) with countries such as Bulgaria, Romania, and the Czech Republic, but also Nordic (n = 69) countries such as Lithuania, and Confucian Asian countries such as China (n = 101) were

represented in this study. Relatively little is known about organizational behavior in these parts of the world, partly because these include former communist countries. However, due to globalization, directing attention to these countries becomes increasingly important. Describing and comparing meetings across national settings is an important basis for understanding possible cultural differences in how meetings are held, and to study these differences in more depth (Gelfand et al., 2007).

This study contributes to the field of cultural differences in communication settings by measuring some of the structural and psychological features that characterize face-to-face meetings as a frequently used form of organized communication in work settings. It adds to the insights gained from studies on cultural differences in communication using other media, such as internet planning tools (Reinecke, Nguyen, Bernstein, Näf, & Gajos, 2013); virtual meetings (Dekker, Rutte, & Van den Berg, 2008); and email communication (Holtbrügge et al., 2013). Much of the knowledge on meetings in an international context is anecdotal and may to some degree contain biases and stereotypes. By systematically assessing the phenomena using a standardized survey, these stereotypes may be lessened somewhat.

A comparison of respondents' perceptions regarding psychological characteristics of meetings only showed significant differences with regard to mood. One might have expected differences on participation in particular, as this behavior would be most closely related to cultural dimensions such as power distance and individualism (Hofstede, 1980). The findings did not reflect these, even though this appears to be counterintuitive. Power distance between the participants may also affect the meaning of the word participation. Sagie and Aycan (2003) describe different interpretations of participation, such as what they refer to as paternalistic participation in organizations. This would be called participation in some cultures with high power distance, for example Japan, where employees have the opportunity to speak, but are expected to comply with what the leader says. In such a style, leaders elicit

ideas from employees by seeking consensus but then expect that their employees honor and obey all of their decisions. In Western eyes, this type of participation may in fact appear to be very directive and tight. By contrast, in countries with relatively low power distance (e.g., US, The Netherlands) it is expected that different points of view are voiced and may actually influence what a leader will do. Sagie and Aycan (2003) conclude that procedures believed to be participation in one environment may be considered non-participation in another.

Thus, within the perspective of cultural relativity, participation could have a different meaning within each culture, and meeting participants would then be responding with reference to this particular cultural standard, obscuring possible objective differences. In other words, a cultural coloring of the results may have occurred. This psychological restriction of survey answers on the basis of relative reference points has been observed in other work-related phenomena, such as job and income satisfaction (e.g., Bonsang & Van Soest, 2012). Alternatively to this cultural relativity-reasoning, there are at least two other possibilities. First, the frameworks employed in this study do not sufficiently distinguish the relevant dimensions in relation to *cultural* differences. It might be more useful to focus on more concrete behaviors linked to time-related issues, communication habits other than high or low context communication, or meeting procedures and processes rather than classifying countries according to more general dimensions such as used in the frameworks we followed here. Second, one might argue that meetings are essentially the same all over the world. For instance, work meetings may have been copied or transplanted from more recent American models on how to manage organizations that still dominate current thinking of best practices in organizations. Given that meetings serve one or more circumscribed purposes (e.g., decision-making, information sharing) that may be important to any business irrespectively of its geographical location, and are thus characterized by functional similarity, meetings may be similar across cultures.

Ultimately, we cannot be assured which of these two opposing explanations actually account for our finding. Alternative study designs such as observation along with interviews would be suitable to study the meaning of some of the psychological constructs such as participation in meetings, and thus of comparable levels of self-rated participation between countries, in more depth. One study based on observations along with perceptions of participation (Rogerson-Revell, 2008), however, still revealed a discrepancy between the two types of measurements. In a comparison between English and non-English speakers in the meetings, the non-English indicated they participated less, whereas actual observations, using objective timing of interactions, did not fully support this. Psychological perceptions may shape the outcomes of meetings more strongly than objective meeting characteristics.

On the other hand, we found differences in comfortable mood that we interpret such that countries with more power distance (Latin European and Middle Eastern cluster) have participants feeling more tense than those with less power distance (Anglo and Germanic cluster). Measuring mood as a more concrete and emotional construct may allow for a better assessment of the meaning of experiences in the meeting than cognitive attitudinal measures. This is something to consider for future assessments of cultural differences in meetings.

Practical Implications

The study also provides important practical implications. As face-to-face meetings will most likely not disappear in spite of technological advancements, it is important to realize how meeting management may be improved in different settings. After all, the return on investment of meetings may be heightened by taking into account some simple principles (Rogelberg, Shanock, & Scott, 2012). In an international context this could be, for example, the awareness that meetings in Turkey may usually not start on time. Such awareness will help understand some of the behaviors when conducting meetings there, and an outsider may benefit from this knowledge.

Another example may be to critically evaluate how many people should be in the meeting. This study, similar to Cohen et al. (2011), reveals that larger size meetings are less effective than smaller ones, at least psychologically speaking. However, there may also be positive aspects of larger meeting sizes such as a greater variety of different information and possibilities of input (cf. team research; Kozlowski & Bell, 2003). The cultural context in which a meeting is held may shape whether meeting participants can capitalize on a larger meeting size, or are bound to suffer from coordination difficulties and lowered functioning.

For any cultural outsider chairing a meeting in another country, it may be necessary to state explicit rules (see Cohen et al., 2011) to have everyone on the same page. These rules clarify, for example, what the facilitator expects with regard to participation, how decisions should be made, and what is expected in terms of speaking turns and so on. Usually, acknowledging differences and making them explicit is more functional than assuming everyone has the same expectations. Yet, this sounds as a typical low context view of holding meetings, and it may be worthwhile to consider in depth how facilitators in meetings with high-context cultures view this.

Limitations and Further Research

Despite the contributions of our study and the useful implications derived from it, we also acknowledge some limitations. Some have to do with the sample employed. The cluster sizes vary, the clusters were not obtained using probability sampling, and the clustering itself may be disputed. For example, the GLOBE project includes Greece and Cyprus in the Eastern European cluster, whereas many may consider these countries among the Latin European. Or, when considering Turkey, it may not be Middle Eastern in many respects. Another issue related to the sample is that within the clusters, some countries have been represented in an unbalanced manner, as for example was the case for Turkey in the Middle

Eastern cluster. And, as we indicated before, only seven of the ten GLOBE clusters were represented in our sample.

The classification of countries according to the context framework would benefit from some refinement, as indicated by Kittler, Rygl, and Mackinnon (2011). Using a standardized measure (Warner-Søderholm, 2013) may support this approach.

Keeping in mind that the respondents all completed a questionnaire in English which may entail possible restrictions (Harzing, 2006), it is probable that the respondents were the more cosmopolitan respondents within their countries. Nevertheless, as the business world is globalizing, this may not be problematic; English is used as the global business language in the majority of countries around the world.

Another feature of the sample is that the respondents are rather young, and the sample may be biased towards early career professionals. Those who are occupying more senior positions also are involved in more meetings. For example, senior level managers are said to spend 23 hours a week on meetings (Tobia & Becker, 1990); an overview of studies conducted between 1960 and 1994 on the time spent in meetings according to executive roles is provided in Romano and Nunamaker (2001). All of these studies indicate much more time spent in meetings than the participants in our sample. The facilitators in our sample indeed spent more time in meetings, and they were more satisfied. It is important to control for this role in future studies, as we did in the present study. Another feature important in future measurement would be to use anchoring vignettes (Bonsang & Van Soest, 2012) or other types of measures such as behavioral scenarios as a solution to the problems associated with cross-cultural validity (Peng, Nisbett, & Wong, 1997).

Building on our findings, we would like to discuss some avenues for future research on cultural issues in meetings. Aspects that we addressed are time-related issues, the role of the facilitator, and participation from a cross-cultural perspective. Another aspect that could

be explored further is the role of the English language in meetings in non-English speaking countries (Rogerson-Revell, 2008). Not only the perceptions of participation, but also the power dimensions associated with the dominant language are interesting aspects of organizational life which may have many implications for the implementation of decisions taken in meetings.

Not only the location but also the international makeup of the team, the values of the team members, and their influence on team processes may be an interesting topic to focus on when studying face-to-face meetings (Bouncken, 2004; Bouncken & Winkler, 2010). Connaughton and Shuffler (2007) provide an overview of international virtual team meetings that can direct research efforts in this area.

When focusing more on the processes (see chapter …in this book) rather than input variables such as structural characteristics as we did, studying the interactions of team members in an international context becomes even more relevant. Social network analysis may allow more in-depth insights into the interactions among meeting participants.

Conclusion

Concluding, we provided a preliminary overview of structural and psychological characteristics in different countries that can be used as a starting point to develop hypotheses on cross-cultural issues relevant to meetings. As our study shows, meeting size, duration, lateness, and mood are among those meeting characteristics worthy of more in-depth investigation. Another clear learning outcome from our study is the recognition that relying on attitudinal survey measures only may not be sufficient to interpret and understand the cultural meaning behind. Therefore, attention should be devoted to additional forms of assessing meeting-related variables, either by supplementing them with anchoring points, objective observations, or additional qualitative information. Future studies focusing on

cross-cultural differences in meetings will be of practical use but also have the potential to further enrich the theoretical framework of meeting science.

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Appendix

	Anglo	Confucian Asia	Eastern Europe	Germanic	Latin Europe	Middle Eastern	Nordic	Total	Context
Australia	7	-	-	-	-	-	-	7	1
Austria	-	-	-	6	-	-	-	6	1
Belgium	-	-	-	14	-	-	-	14	1
Bosnia Herzegovina	-	-	1	-	-	-	-	1	0
Bulgaria	-	-	39	-	-	-	-	39	0
Canada	3	-	-	-	-	-	-	3	1
China	-	90	-	-	-	-	-	90	0
Croatia	-	-	1	-	-	-	-	1	0
Cyprus	-	-	-	-	8	-	-	8	0
Czech Republic	-	-	80	-	-	-	-	80	0
Denmark	-	-	-	-	-	-	4	4	1
Egypt	-	-	-	-	-	2	-	2	0
Estonia	-	-	-	-	-	-	3	3	0
Finland	-	-	-	-	-	-	17	17	1
France	-	-	-	-	4	-	-	4	0
Georgia	-	-	1	-	-	-	-	1	0
Germany	-	-	-	57	-	-	-	57	1
Great Britain	41	-	-	-	-	-	-	41	1
Greece	-	-	33	-	-	-	-	33	0
Hong Kong	-	2	-	-	-	-	-	2	0
Hungary	-	-	5	-	-	-	-	5	0
Italy	-	-	-	-	7	-	-	7	0
Japan	-	1	-	-	-	-	-	1	0
Latvia	-	-	-	-	-	-	7	7	0
Libya	-	-	-	-	-	1	-	1	0
Lithuania	-	-	-	-	-	-	35	35	0
Macedonia	-	-	1	-	-	-	-	1	0
Netherlands	-	-	-	50	-	-	-	50	1
Norway	-	-	-	-	-	-	3	3	1
Poland	-	-	11	-	-	-	-	11	0
Portugal	-	-	-	-	9	-	-	9	0
Romania	-	-	47	-	-	-	-	47	0
Russia	-	-	17	-	-	-	-	17	0
Saudi Arabia	-	-	-	-	-	1	-	1	0
Serbia	-	-	3	-	-	-	-	3	0
Singapore	-	2	-	-	-	-	-	2	0
Slovakia	-	-	3	-	-	-	-	3	0

	Anglo	Confucian Asia	Eastern Europe	Germanic	Latin Europe	Middle Eastern	Nordic	Total	Context
South Africa	1	-	-	-	-	-	-	1	1
Spain	-	-	-	-	9	-	-	9	0
Sweden	-	-	-	-	-	-	1	1	1
Switzerland	-	-	-	9	-	-	-	9	1
Taiwan	-	6	-	-	-	-	-	6	0
Turkey	-	-	-	-	-	26	-	26	0
United Arab Emirates	-	-	-	-	-	3	-	3	0
United States	39	-	-	-	-	-	-	39	1
Total	91	101	242	136	37	33	70	710	

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